

HOW TO SPOT BULLSHIT

While we have tried to cover as many purely marketing terms and malpractices as possible, we cannot possibly hope to list them all down. Besides, we could make a list for absolutely everything that you might encounter out there right now, and it would be obsolete in a few years at best. There will be new products and new product categories that will crop up that will reinvent the poo thrown at you by that special primate species called marketers. It is for this reason that we have dedicated the last page of this cover story to help you identify all future BS from a mile away. If something smells funny, it probably is, so buyer beware.

If you cannot understand what a specification means right away, it is probably not relevant to making the purchase. Terms such as “transform magnetic interfaces” or “synthesize granular vortals” are just random jargon and mean absolutely nothing. They can show up in any product category. The same can be said for generic feature listings such as “superior performance”. Superior to what? It could be superior to a rock, and still be “superior performance”, right? All these things have to be ignored as BS before making a purchase.

Manufacturers and companies often come up with their own names for common technologies, to make it appear like they have a superior product. If there is a TM logo next to a specification, chances are that it is not some cutting-edge, patented technology that the manufacturer alone is providing. Instead, if there is actually a patent or one applied for, the manufacturer will proudly list it as such using terms such as patent pending, or patented. If not, it's probably just a made up term that they're using to describe some common feature. It's a bit like saying dihydrogen monoxide instead of water. A tech example is Qualcomm's Quick Charging

feature, which is called various names by different manufacturers.

If the specification sheet uses generic adjectives instead of particular standards and technologies, then, again, that is just plain faeces! Refer to the terms we used earlier to describe the sound quality of audio equipment. At other times, the descriptions may not even be related to the category of the device at all. For example, if the biggest boast a TV has is about its speakers, that means it has nothing new to offer in terms of display technology. Heck, we've even seen a TV that contained “big rocket, small price” in the spec sheet!

Another clear indication of BS is the use of capitals or exclamations in the specification sheet. This should right away tell you that the product in question is not worth your window shopping time, let alone the price asked for. If the product uses capitals and exclamations at the same time, you seriously need to question why you landed on that page. Better to save up and increase your budget. Any use of superlatives should also similarly be seen as a red flag.

If the product image has a badge on top, search for the contents. These may be badges of unrecognised “awards”, or fake standards that do not exist. They are meant to deceive the users into thinking that the product is actually a stand out that was recognised by a major technology publication. If the badge just says something like “100% quality”, it is absolutely meaningless. Unless it's a Digit badge, because we've very stingy when giving out those.

When it comes to specs wars, an easy way to identify bull is to see the way the zeroes are listed. A genuine product will simply say “rated for 60 million keystrokes”, while a product that has put in the specification solely to get more sales, will say something on the lines of “rated for 8,000,000 keystrokes”. The same goes for ratios, if they are reduced to the lowest

form, then it is likely to be a genuine product. The problem here is that even perfectly fine, high quality products are susceptible to list specifications that they think will get them more sales.

If the description page is more about how the product was made, as against what the product is actually capable of, it is safe to ignore all of it. As a consumer, what went on to get the device into the market should be rarely of interest to you. Audio products are particularly good at this, and can go to extreme levels such as describing the lighting and weather conditions in the exotic location where the wood for the product was grown. High-end and low-end products both indulge in descriptions of this sort. The same goes for an unnecessary amount of space given to describing the design or the product, or worse, the design philosophies guiding the design.

When it comes to cutting edge technologies, or entirely new product categories, you need to figure out if all the features are relevant to you. For example, even though 4K TVs are fairly common in the market, there is still a dearth of content. The same goes for VR headsets, or smart-home speakers which are currently crippled in the country for a lack of support for local products and services. In any case, unless you are an enthusiast, it is better to wait a while for a product category to mature, and get cheaper, before investing in it.

If there are qualifiers for a specification, such as “enhanced dynamic range” or “final zoom”, then again there is a reason to be suspicious. It is very likely that the particular specification being listed is not the native or actual specification, but a variant that is calculated by the manufacturer.

The best way to not get fooled by marketing speak is to make a list of specifications and requirements that you need. Then when choosing a product, it is best to ignore other advertised jargon as bull! 